Topic, Focus, and Focussing Devices

Context • Topic • Topicalisation • Focus • Focussing devices

Prosody/intonation • Clefts • Fronting • Repetition • Word order

1. Meaning Is More Than Words

A sentence does not communicate meaning independently of context.

Context includes the preceding discourse, physical situation, speaker/hearer knowledge, shared assumptions, time, place and communicative purpose.

The same sentence can answer different questions and therefore highlight different information.

Example: “Ravi bought the book.” Depending on context, the important information may be Ravi, bought, or the book.

Information structure explains how speakers organise what is being talked about and what is presented as especially informative.

Why Context Matters: A Simple Example

Question: “Who bought the book?” → “RAVI bought the book.”

Question: “What did Ravi buy?” → “Ravi bought THE BOOK.”

Question: “What did Ravi do?” → “Ravi BOUGHT the book.”

The words are largely the same, but the interpretation of what is most important changes.

Prosody, word order and constructional choices can signal this difference.

Context and Discourse Interpretation

Context helps the hearer identify the discourse topic.

Context determines what information is already accessible or given.

Context helps identify which part of an utterance supplies new, contrastive or corrective information.

Context can make an otherwise ambiguous sentence interpretable.

2. What Is a Topic?

The topic is what an utterance or discourse segment is primarily about.

A topic provides a point of orientation for the information that follows.

Example: “As for the new library, it opens next Monday.” → “the new library” is the topic.

Example: “My brother is studying linguistics.” → “my brother” is the likely topic in a neutral context.

A topic is often, but not always, the grammatical subject.

Topic: Topic vs. Subject

SUBJECT is a grammatical relation in sentence structure.

TOPIC is a discourse/information-structural notion: what the utterance is about.

Example: “The old house, I really like.” → “the old house” is topic, but it is not the ordinary subject of “I really like.”

Example: “The children are playing.” → “the children” can simultaneously be subject and topic.

Therefore, subject and topic frequently overlap but should not be treated as identical.

Topic Examples

“Regarding the exam, the students are worried.” → exam = topic.

“As for Delhi, the weather has changed.” → Delhi = topic.

“This book, I have already read.” → this book = topic.

“My sister, she works in Pune.” → my sister = discourse topic; she is the grammatical subject.

Topics may be explicitly marked or inferred from discourse context.

3. What Is Topicalisation?

Topicalisation is a construction in which an element is moved or positioned at the beginning of a clause to establish it as the topic.

Typical English pattern: Topic + clause.

Example: “This book, I really enjoyed.”

Neutral order: “I really enjoyed this book.”

Topicalisation changes information structure without necessarily changing the basic propositional content.

4. What Is Focus?

Focus is the part of an utterance that is presented as especially informative, prominent, contrastive or relevant to the current question under discussion.

Focus often identifies the information that answers a question or distinguishes one alternative from others.

Question: “Who called?” → “ANITA called.” → Anita is focus.

Question: “What did Anita buy?” → “Anita bought A BOOK.” → a book is focus.

Focus can be signalled by prosody, syntax, word order, morphology and context.

Focus and New Information

Focus is often associated with new information, but focus is not identical to “new information.”

Contrastive focus may highlight information that is already known but is being contrasted.

Example: “I said MONDAY, not TUESDAY.” → Monday is contrastive focus.

Corrective focus: “No, RAHUL wrote the paper.”

Therefore, focus concerns communicative prominence, not simply whether an item has been mentioned before.

Topic vs. Focus

TOPIC: what the utterance is about.

FOCUS: what is highlighted as especially informative, relevant or contrastive.

Example: “As for Priya, SHE bought the tickets.” → Priya = topic; she bought the tickets may contain focus on the identity of the buyer.

Example: “Priya bought THE TICKETS.” → Priya can be topic; the tickets can be focus.

A sentence can contain both topic and focus, and their roles are determined in relation to discourse context.

Characteristics of Topic

- Provides a discourse frame or point of orientation.
- Answers or anticipates “What are we talking about?”
- Often accessible or salient in context.
- Frequently appears in initial position, though languages differ.
- May be marked by special particles, constructions or intonation.
- Can persist across several sentences or shift to a new entity.
- May or may not coincide with the grammatical subject.

Characteristics of Focus

- Carries heightened information-structural prominence.
- Often answers “What is the relevant/new/contrastive information?”
- Typically occurs late in the sentence and complements the presupposed information typically present early in the sentence
- is of high communicative interest
- Can be contrastive or corrective.
- Its interpretation depends strongly on the question or discourse context.
- May be expressed through stress, prosody, syntax, word order, repetition or special constructions.

5. What Is a Focussing Device?

A focussing device is a linguistic strategy used to make a constituent or piece of information especially prominent or salient.

Focussing devices help the listener identify what the speaker considers particularly informative, contrastive, corrective or important.

Some devices are prosodic; others are syntactic or lexical.

Major devices discussed here: prosody/intonation, cleft constructions, fronting, topicalisation, repetition and word order.

Different devices can operate together.

Focussing Device 1: Prosody / Intonation

In spoken language, prosody is one of the most important ways to signal focus.

Focused material commonly receives greater pitch prominence, stress, duration or intensity.

Example: “RAVI bought the book.” → prominence on Ravi answers “Who bought it?”

“Ravi bought THE BOOK.” → prominence on book answers “What did Ravi buy?”

Intonation therefore interacts with context to guide the listener toward the intended interpretation.

Prosodic Focus: Same Words, Different Meaning

“Maya borrowed the CAR.” → focus on car.

“MAYA borrowed the car.” → focus on Maya.

“Maya BORROWED the car.” → focus on the action.

The lexical words remain the same, but changing prosodic prominence changes the likely question being answered.

In writing, capitals are used here only to represent spoken prominence; normal writing may use italics or other contextual cues.

Focussing Device 2: Cleft Constructions

A cleft construction divides a proposition into two parts so that one constituent receives special prominence.

Common English pattern: “It was X who/that Y.”

Neutral: “Ravi solved the problem.”

Cleft: “It was RAVI who solved the problem.”

The cleft construction foregrounds Ravi as the focused constituent.

Clefts are particularly useful for contrast, correction and answering specific questions.

Types / Examples of Clefting

IT-CLEFT: “It was Priya who won the prize.”

WH-CLEFT / PSEUDO-CLEFT: “What Priya bought was a new laptop.”

Example question: “What did Priya buy?” → “What Priya bought was a new laptop.”

Negative/corrective context: “It wasn't Ravi who called; it was Amit.”

Clefting changes the information structure while preserving a related underlying proposition.

Focussing Device 3: Fronting

Fronting places a constituent at the beginning of a clause, giving it special discourse prominence.

Example: Neutral: “I really like this song.”

Fronted: “This song, I really like.”

Fronting can establish a topic, create contrast or make a constituent prominent.

Fronting and topicalisation overlap substantially in English descriptions; the exact terminology varies across linguistic frameworks.

Context determines whether the fronted element functions mainly as topic, contrast or focus.

Fronting for Contrast

“This book, I liked; that one, I disliked.”

The fronted constituents establish contrasting discourse alternatives.

Fronting can reduce processing effort by presenting the discourse frame before the rest of the clause.

It can also create stylistic emphasis.

In other languages, fronting may be associated with specific grammatical focus constructions.

Focussing Device 4: Topicalisation

Topicalisation can function as a focussing device when the topicalised constituent is made prominent for contrast or special attention.

Example: “THIS PROBLEM, we need to solve first.”

The topicalised phrase identifies the discourse domain while also receiving prominence.

Example: “The RED file, I need—not the blue one.”

Topic and focus are analytically distinct, but topicalisation can create focus-like prominence in particular contexts.

Focussing Device 5: Repetition

Repetition can make information salient and signal that the repeated element is important.

Example: “I said the RED folder—the RED folder, not the blue one.”

Repetition may express correction, insistence, clarification or emphasis.

In discourse, repeating a word can help maintain attention on a particular entity or proposition.

Prosodic emphasis often accompanies repetition in speech.

Repetition and Information Structure

Simple repetition is not automatically focus, but repeated material can acquire special prominence depending on context.

Example: “Who should present?” — “Anita. Anita should present.”

The repetition reinforces the selected alternative.

Repetition may also support topic continuity: “The library is crowded. The library needs more space.”

Thus, repetition can serve both discourse cohesion and emphasis.

Focussing Device 6: Word Order

Word order can influence which constituent is interpreted as prominent.

English has relatively fixed canonical word order, so departures from neutral order can have discourse effects.

Compare: “John bought the flowers.” vs. “The flowers, John bought.”

Languages with freer word order may use constituent position more extensively to distinguish topic, focus and background.

Word order should always be interpreted together with prosody and context.

Word Order and Information Packaging

Canonical order often presents a relatively neutral information structure.

Marked order can place an element in a discourse-prominent position.

Example: “THIS book I recommend.” → fronted demonstrative + prosodic prominence.

Example: “Into the room came the professor.” → unusual order can create a particular discourse presentation.

The exact focus interpretation depends on the language, construction and context.

8. Topic–Focus Structure in a Dialogue

Q: “What happened to the new students?”

A: “The new students have joined the linguistics course.”

Topic: “the new students” — what the response is about.

Focus: “have joined the linguistics course” — the principal information supplied.

Q: “Which course did they join?”

A: “They joined the LINGUISTICS course.” — the focus changes because the question changes.

20. Summary

CONTEXT determines how information is interpreted in discourse.

TOPIC = what the utterance is about.

TOPICALISATION = positioning a constituent to establish or maintain discourse prominence/topic status.

FOCUS = information presented as especially informative, contrastive, corrective or relevant.

FOCUSSING DEVICES make information prominent through prosody or grammatical/lexical organisation.

Major devices: prosody/intonation, clefts, fronting, topicalisation, repetition and word order.

Topic and focus must be analysed in relation to context, discourse and the question under discussion.